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The Endurance of Pagan Religions: Interpretations and Inspirations Through Stone

The role of art, in the context of Greek religion, was to inspire pagan worship within city-states and rural communities by means of a visual aid. One would think that those in ancient times would have confused the gods for one another as they worshipped many, but this did not appear to be the case. Yes, modern archaeologists and classicists cannot tell the difference between some artwork compared to others there was damage over time and valuable pieces of iconography are missing, especially when it comes to sculptures; sculptures can be missing any range of items such as Zeus' lightning bolt - to distinguish him from Poseidon who typically holds a trident - all the way to a missing head. Even though the Greeks followed a pagan religion with multiple gods, there were factors that allowed for a universal knowledge of distinguishing one god from another such as iconography associated with certain gods, what type of clothing they were wearing, and inscriptions. This essay will discuss the engagement of temple statuary, from the Archaic and Classical Periods, in the interpretation of gods - specifically Zeus, Athena, and Apollo - within major cult centres across the ancient Greek world; and how statuary inspired and invoked worship within these cult centres.

Greek art, unlike most modern art, was made for a reason rather than 'just for fun', though that isn't to say that people in ancient times did not appreciate the effort

and detail that went into the making of such magnificent works. One major reason that statues of the gods were made was as a means to give thanks to specific deities. Such occasions ranged from a city being given 'divine' protection during a war or a Greek politician being elected as a civic official or said politician attempting to be elected as a civic official - thereby using the statue as a means to gain favour among the public and the divine, although this happened much more in the Roman culture. Statues may have also been commissioned during festivals, such as the Anthesteria, where it is believed that a statue of Dionysus was put on a small wheeled ship which was then led in a procession from the sea to Athens in order to signify the god's arrival from the sea.

The Classical Period-style of statuary is the most well-known with its realistic muscular lines and life-like form but with unrealistic human proportions, especially when it came to male statues who were sculpted to look like what modern people call bodybuilders, and who, as many people of this day and age are aware, are far and few in between. Female statues were fully clothed in the Archaic Period as one can see from *kore* statues and it was not until the 400s in the Classical Period where goddesses and deities were sculpted in the nude just like many of the male dedication statues. One example is the cult statue of Aphrodite that had been commissioned for the Temple of Aphrodite at Knidos. Apparently this statue was so beautiful that it not only invoked cult worship but also sexual lust in men; there is a written account where a man tried to have sexual relations with the statue itself. If that does not say that the goddess of sexual love was good at her job then I don't know what else could; Aphrodite in the form

of a visual art piece, of all things, held sway over a man by being all that encompassed sexual passion and brought about this passion within a visitor to her temple.

Greek statues were made from many different materials ranging from wood - which did not survive over the years - all the way to the difficult-to-make bronze statues. While there does not seem to be any religious significance connected to any of these materials, the reason for their evolution is clear; as the Greeks gained more knowledge, they realized that there were materials stronger that lasted longer than wood which is why the favored material for sculpting became stone. The Greeks may also have gotten the idea to use stone from the Egyptians as there is obvious evidence that the *kore* and *kouroi* statues are inspired by Egyptian statues which were also made of stone. Archaic statues were typically made from materials such as wood and stone while Classic statues were made from stone, bronze and even ivory and gold. Though this does not have much to do with this paper's topic, it is always good to know the background of materials, especially when looking at a changing form of artistic medium such as statuary and how these different mediums could alter the powerful presence of the divine.

When someone mentions Greek statues, most people would probably first think of the famous bleached statues housed in museums around the world that depict deities and heroes in scenes from epic poetry and mythological retellings. Myths and ancient literature became a large part of artisanal inspiration in both the Archaic and Classical Periods and from these stories the gods - the Olympians in particular - gained personalities to go with their anthropomorphic bodies. Their personalities could be

shown by the way they interacted with humans and other gods and they were apparently much taller than humans so that they could have a physical showcase of their divinity and otherworldliness. Epic poems were a relatively decent source of worship within temples or in public worship centers as there was an invocation to the gods where the speaker would address the god by a specific epithet attached to their name so that the god would know what kind of request was being made. Think of it like this: there is an old tv show called *Green Acres* where the character Sam Drucker, who owned the general store, would change both his career choice and personality simply by switching his hat, as he was also the newspaper editor, notary, constable, justice of the peace, and the postman. Epithets are the gods switching their career choice and could be seen by the way the god was posing, their mannerisms, and the symbols surrounding them as well as surviving inscriptions; this isn't to say that every sculpture of say, Athena, had an epithet attached to it but many did, especially within Athens.

The Temple of Zeus at Olympia used to hold a grand chryselephantine statue - a statue made from ivory and gold being placed on top of a wooden base - of Zeus that to this day is still called one of the seven wonders of the ancient world even though it was destroyed by a fire. This statue had apparently been over 40 feet tall and had Zeus seated on a throne, with his feet resting on a footrest that depicted an Amazonomachy; he held Nike, the goddess of victory, in his one hand, and held a staff in the other which had an eagle on top, his head had been crowned with an olive leaf wreath, just as the winners of the Olympic games were. The sculptor of this structure, Phidias, said that he had been inspired by a quote from Homer's *Iliad* in his representation of the sky god

where Zeus, with a nod of his head, shook Olympus. If this statue had to be given a name, a fitting one would be Zeus *Olympios* for he was the ruler of the Olympians and the patron of the Olympic games.

This statue was apparently so magnificent that it could move a person's soul and was so realistic that it was as if Zeus was actually present among mortals. Statues representing the Greek gods had their "very own modes of translating the otherworldly nature of the divine into the human sphere in the way in which they positioned themselves between the opposing poles of iconicity and aniconism, in their various sizes above, below and identical to the average size of the human body and in their various fabrics" (Kindt 4) and Zeus became an even more respected within the religious communities after they left Olympia. This statue of Zeus made it seem as if he would break through the roof if he stood up, like in the Disney movie *Hercules* where the statue of Zeus came to life so that the god could aid his son, Hercules, who is in need of his guidance. I am sure that many Greeks would have been both alarmed and in awe if Zeus' statue had indeed come to life and it would have taken the term, naturalism, to a whole new level or artistry. What is really great about this statue is that it is very likely that it had many interpretations from different points of view across the Greek landscape because the Olympic games were a time for all the Greek city-states to come together, compete, and worship. This statue encompassed all of Zeus' titles and set him up for his future Roman title of Zeus *Optimus Maximus* which means 'the best and greatest'.

Greek religion was used as inspiration for art and that art was then used to inspire further worship. When a worshipper would walk into a temple, such as the

Parthenon, they were greeted by cult images including frescoes, metopes and multiple statues of the designated goddess, Athena, and other gods. As discussed earlier in regard to the cult statue of Aphrodite at Knidos, the statue was a full invocation of the goddess herself as it could not only cause those who saw her stone-form to worship her but also to love her as only she knows; sexually. Athena did not invoke sexual love as this was not her nature as a virgin goddess but she did encourage the wisdom and courage of her cult worshippers. Her iconography typically included an owl, which symbolizes wisdom, a battle helmet, and either a spear or sword in one hand and sometimes her shield in the other; Athena's shield typically had the head of Medusa and multiple snakes carved onto it. The large statue of Athena *Parthenos* that used to reside within the Parthenon was said to have been magnificent as it was chryselephantine, like the statue of Zeus at Olympia discussed earlier, and was apparently almost 40 feet tall. The statue was placed on a pedestal that had the birth of Pandora carved onto it. In Athena's one hand she held Nike, the goddess of victory, and in her other hand she held a shield by her feet and had a spear resting against the same shoulder. We are very lucky that there was a surviving text which depicted what the statue looked like; there are also versions of the statue on coins that have been found during archaeological digs.

What is interesting about the Athenian statue is that it depicted Athena after a battle won, with victory in her hand - quite literally as Nike was in her hand - even though *parthenos* means 'virgin' or 'maiden'; yet this statue could be representing the purity in her determination to win battles and keep her intelligence without being

distracted by sex and sin. The other reasoning that the epithet *parthenos* may be attached to her is that this epithet was typically attached to Athena within the city of Athens, who she was the patron of; although it would be more appropriate, visually-wise, for this statue to have been called Athena *Promachos* as it physically portrayed her as a champion of a victorious battle, or even Athena *Nike*, as she was holding Nike. This is one of those great examples that emphasizes how there was no one true way to view a statue of a deity; there is a good possibility that even a Spartan would have appreciated this statue of Athena for her battle prowess and strength of character. No matter what epithet is attached to this statue, there is no denying that it must have been so glorious that it would have immediately caused a person to only think about her while they were in her presence and to worship her, even if it was only with their eyes and their silent words.

We are lucky that there was a copy of this statue made in Nashville, Tennessee, although it is not made of the same material of ivory and gold covering a wooden base, and is instead made of modern enduring materials. Even so, she is still larger than life and as Julia Kindt says in her written work, *Rethinking Greek Religion*, the statue of Athena “articulated the otherworldly nature of the gods through her size and the precious materials used for her fabrication” (Kindt 4). Even with Athena’s statue gone from Greece, her presence is still everywhere as the “Parthenon’s various sculptures depict myths concerning the history of Athena and her patronage of the city, myths of Greeks - especially Athenians - and gods fighting various rebellious forces, and the

creation of the first woman” (94) as Barringer points out in *Art, Myth, and Ritual in Classical Greece*.

Apollo was a multifaceted god within the Greek world as he was the god of music, poetry, healing and prophecy as well as archery like his twin sister, Artemis. What this meant is that his function among different cities and cults changed based on which epithet of Apollo they were worshipping. In Delphi, Apollo was the patron god of the temple that housed the Oracle of Delphi and was known as Apollo *Akesios* which means ‘averted of evil’ or as *Pythian* Apollo, Pytho being the original name of Delphi and in coordination with the python that was killed by Apollo, or even Apollo *Delphinus*. There is no record of any of the statues that may have been at Delphi but there is evidence of a statue that had been at the Sanctuary of Apollo at Amyclae, south of Sparta. This statue had been made of wood and built in the Archaic period, it unfortunately did not survive over the years as it was made of wood which is an organic material and tends to break down or catch fire much easier than other materials. This statue had been bronze plated and stood on top of an altar, or tomb, of his lover Hyacinthus. There is evidence of this statue on coins and some ancient writings and through these reproductions it is obvious that this statue meant a lot to the Greeks, the Spartans especially. This statue had supposedly been simple but had been a different version of Apollo than those seen at his sanctuaries or his portrayal in Athens. Pausanias said that Apollo held a spear in his hands and a bow with a helmet on his head instead of the long hair and youthful face that is typically expected of Apollo.

There is certainly a question as to what epithet this statue had been formed under, whether it was simply Apollo *Amyclaeus*, or Apollo *Alexicacus* which means 'warding off evil' or Apollo *Arcitenens* which means 'bow-carrying'. This statue, especially since it is no longer around, seems like it would have been very open to interpretation and worship but that with the altar of Hyacinthus as his base, those worshipping Apollo had to remember his mortal lover and that gods too can mourn those that they lose. Apollo also had a statue at Metropolis that was unlike his normal characterizations in that Apollo was dressed in hoplite armor with a beard, instead of a shaved youthful face, and was holding a spear. The only reason that archaeologists know that this is Apollo is because of an inscription on the statue indicating so and it is the only place in Greece, other than Sparta, where this is seen. The function of this version of Apollo is unknown and of an archaic time. Plato mentions in his work, the *Laws*, that "some of the gods we see with our eyes and we honour them, of others we honour the images, raising statues of them which we adore; and though they are lifeless, yet we imagine that the living Gods have a good will and gratitude to us on this account" (Jowett 361) and he makes a good point that even though the statues are not actually the gods, yet they are there to be reminders of the dedication that the Greeks have for their religion and their gods. So even though Apollo had so titles attached to him, such as Apollo the Healer compared to Apollo the Diviner, worshipping him, no matter which epithet you ascribed to him or his statues of worship, was all that mattered was that there was reciprocation and a "continuum of a cultural environment that functioned for centuries." (Palagia 295)

Greeks had ritualistic communities that were the foundation of their pagan religions because without worship, the gods' power becomes weak. Greeks took their worship of gods very seriously as one can see from this snapshot into the religious world. One problem with ancient Greek religion is that there are scarce surviving texts - if there were any written down to begin with - that describe the experiences of Greeks visiting temples in regions other than their own. One cannot guess if a man from Sparta was able to determine that the statue of Zeus they were looking at in Thessaly was different from their own Zeus in Sparta and if Zeus' function within Thessalian society was different from the Spartans. Statues differences may not have mattered between different territories because if there were to be opinions on the 'right' and 'wrong' interpretation of a god, then it would restrict the pagan religion. Kindt says that "the problem is that we can only approximately know the gods in the various shapes in which they reveal themselves to us...the anthropomorphism of the gods is always a compromise between the visible and the invisible, the immanent and the transcendent; it is a way of representing what is ultimately impossible to represent." (Kindt 18) One thing that scholars can decipher from the statues is that they, "in very broad terms...described religious instruction - the prescriptive articulation of the thoughts instilled in worshippers at a given temple or altar." (Spivey 95)

Interpretation of religious Greek statuary had to be left up to the individual as it is their journey to go on in regards to what thoughts and feelings strike them upon viewing these divine beings. The pagan religion of ancient Greece was interesting in that there was no one true version of a deity, as pagan religion was like water, it can form to any

shape as long as there is a vessel to hold it, that vessel can then pass the water to another differently shaped vessel yet the water is still the same even though the holder is different. Worship of gods was the same yet ever-changing as the Greek world transformed and so too did the pagan religion go through a metamorphosis like a living organism; but the relics of the past still remained in the form of statues, especially those from the Archaic and Classical Periods as they were not simply set on beauty and fiction but on creating an atmosphere within a temple by creating “a compromise between the visible and the invisible, the immanent and the transcendent; it is a way of representing what is ultimately impossible to represent” (Kindt 18) and yet artisans tried and tried again in order to create a votive that would endure forever in the mind of a worshipper and that is all that anyone could have asked of them. Their work still endures even to this day to both scholars and artists alike where one cannot help but be fixated and for one moment be transcended into another place where it is only them and the deity who held their gaze.

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"Greek sculpture is worth studying because Greek sculpture is great sculpture" - Nigel Spivey